

"From higher speeds to warm casserole meals, the Shatabdi revolutionised intercity rail travel in India. It took us another 30 years to introduce the Vande Bharat, developed as a better and safer alternative"

— MOHAMMAD JAMSHED, *former Member Traffic, Railway Board, who was present at the inaugural Shatabdi run in 1988*

DID YOU KNOW?

Then railway minister Madhavrao Scindia tasked IIT Delhi with designing a trolley for carrying meals in the Shatabdi, similar to those used in aircraft. It not only had to fit the aisle but also needed to turn conveniently at the end of the coach...and the rest is history

WHEELS OF CHANGE

- **Shatabdi became a symbol of modernisation for India's middle class, which wanted more options for intercity business travel in the post-liberalisation era of 1990s**
- **It transformed the rail experience for Indian travellers—they now enjoy speed, efficiency and premium onboard services**
- **Inspired by Japan's Shinkansen and France's TGV, it laid the groundwork for India's high-speed rail before the emergence of the Vande Bharat Express, a faster and more efficient means to connect India**
- **The indigenously built Vande Bharat trainsets feature distributed power and increased speeds of up to 180 kmph. With it, India has entered the elite group of trainset manufacturers and now aims to build a bullet train**



FROM THE ARCHIVES
Jul. 15, 1988

Shatabdi Express
On the Fast Track

The underframe of the existing 3,900 hp locomotive was redesigned; sophisticated rubber components were used for "shock absorption" and the braking system improved–all this enables the train to travel at up to 160 kmph. But a device has been fitted to apply the brakes automatically, if the speed exceeds 145 kmph.

birth centenary, which was due the next year. It ran between Delhi and Jhansi, via Agra and Gwalior—the home of then railway minister and ex-royal Madhavrao Scindia, who championed the concept. The high-speed rail systems from his visits to Japan and France were the inspiration. "In Japan, we saw the Shinkansen (bullet train)," recalls Union minister and Madhavrao's son Jyotiraditya Scindia, who had accompanied his father on the trip. "He studied the idea of fast trains that would travel point to point with few stoppages, so people could reach their destinations in less time." In France, Madhavrao saw the TGV, which had started operations in 1981. "He noticed how food was served in silver-foil casserole, without plates and cutlery," says Jyotiraditya. "The Shatabdi was the first train in India to serve food like that.... In a way, it was the desi bullet train of its time."

The Shatabdi swiftly became a favourite of India's middle class in the post-liberalisation era of the '90s, catering to business travellers and urban commuters demanding reliable, faster inter-city connections. Over time, the network expanded, linking numerous routes and setting a benchmark for Indian Railways. Efforts to replicate its success through trains like the Tejas Express and Anubhuti coaches fell short. Yet, the Shatabdi's legacy paved the way for the Vande Bharat Express, the first of which was flagged off by Prime Minister Narendra Modi between Delhi and Varanasi on February 15, 2019. A technological leap, the Vande Bharat is an indigenously built trainset, capable of reaching 180 kmph. With distributed power technology and energy-efficient designs, it represents a bold step towards the future.

Meanwhile, only 25 Shatabdi trainsets remain in service, overshadowed by the rise of the Vande Bharats—80 operate in India today. A bullet train is next on the cards. Though no one is admitting it yet, the day may not be far when the Shatabdi Express finally rides into the sunset, having transformed rail travel in the country for ever. ■